

ServiceNow ITSM Lab

Incident Management Walkthrough

May 2026

Lab Environment

This lab uses a ServiceNow Personal Developer Instance (PDI) to simulate real enterprise IT Service Management (ITSM) workflows. ServiceNow is one of the most widely used ITSM platforms in enterprise environments and is a core tool for Tier 1 helpdesk technicians.

Lab Configuration	
Platform	ServiceNow (Australia release — latest)
Instance type	Personal Developer Instance (PDI) — free tier
Access URL	dev389705.service-now.com
Module used	IT Service Management (ITSM) — Incident Management
Role	System Administrator / ITIL User
Ticket worked	INC0010002

Objectives

This lab covers the full incident ticket lifecycle as performed by a Tier 1 helpdesk technician in ServiceNow:

- Navigate the ServiceNow Incident List and understand ticket queue management
- Create a new incident ticket with proper categorization, priority, and assignment
- Work a ticket by updating state, assigning to an agent, and documenting troubleshooting steps via work notes
- Resolve a ticket with a resolution code and detailed resolution notes
- Understand SLA timers and how they drive response and resolution targets

Section 1: ServiceNow ITSM Overview

What is Incident Management?

In ITSM, an Incident is any unplanned interruption or reduction in quality of a service. Incident Management is the process of restoring normal service operation as quickly as possible. For a Tier 1 helpdesk technician, handling incidents is the primary daily function — logging tickets, triaging, troubleshooting, escalating when needed, and resolving.

ServiceNow organizes incidents with the following key fields:

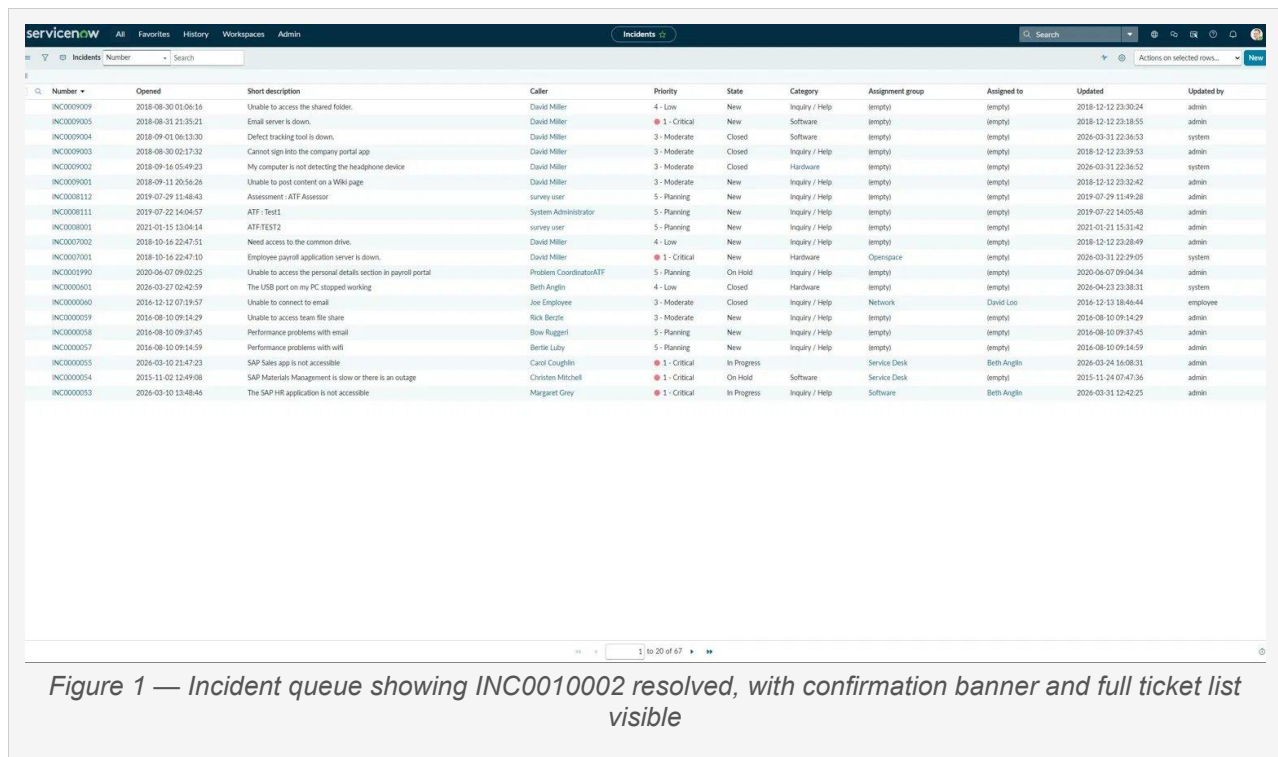
Field	Purpose
Number	Unique ticket ID (e.g. INC0010002) — used to track and reference the ticket
Caller	The end user who reported the issue
Category / Subcategory	Classifies the type of issue (Software, Hardware, Network, etc.)
State	Current status: New, In Progress, On Hold, Resolved, Closed
Impact	How many users are affected (1-High, 2-Medium, 3-Low)
Urgency	How quickly it needs to be resolved (1-High, 2-Medium, 3-Low)
Priority	Auto-calculated from Impact + Urgency — drives SLA timers
Assignment group	The team responsible (e.g. Service Desk, Network, Hardware)
Assigned to	The individual technician working the ticket
Work notes	Internal notes documenting troubleshooting steps — not visible to the user

Section 2: The Incident Queue

Navigating the Incident List

The Incident List is the technician's primary workspace in ServiceNow. It shows all open, in-progress, and recently resolved tickets with key details visible at a glance. Tickets are color-coded by priority — red dot for Critical (P1), no dot for lower priorities.

The confirmation banner "INC0010002 has been resolved" confirms the ticket was successfully closed. INC0010002 appears at the top of the queue with State: Resolved, assigned to ITIL User under the Service Desk assignment group.



Section 3: Creating the Incident Ticket

Ticket Scenario — Account Lockout

A new incident was created to simulate a common Tier 1 helpdesk scenario: a user calling in unable to log into their Windows workstation. This is one of the most frequent tickets at any helpdesk, typically caused by an Active Directory account lockout after too many failed login attempts.

The ticket was created by clicking New in the Incident List and completing the form with the following values:

Field	Value entered
Caller	David Miller
Channel	Phone
Category	Software
Subcategory	Operating System

Impact	2 - Medium
Urgency	2 - Medium
Priority	3 - Moderate (auto-calculated)
Assignment group	Service Desk
Assigned to	ITIL User
Short description	User unable to log into Windows workstation
Description	User reports they are unable to log into their Windows workstation this morning. Receiving "incorrect password" error message. User has not changed their password recently. Possible account lockout.

Figure 2 — INC0010002 ticket form showing all fields completed, State: Resolved, assigned to ITIL User

Section 4: Documenting Work — Notes and Activity Log

Work Notes vs. Customer Comments

ServiceNow distinguishes between two types of notes on a ticket:

- Work notes (yellow) — internal only, visible to agents and managers. Used to document troubleshooting steps, findings, and actions taken. The user never sees these.
- Comments (Customer visible) — visible to the end user. Used to communicate status updates, instructions, or requests for more information.

For this ticket, two work notes were added to document the troubleshooting process step by step, simulating real-time documentation as the issue was worked:

Work note 1 (19:56:35):

"Contacted user via phone. User confirms receiving 'incorrect password' error on Windows login screen. Verified account in Active Directory — account is locked out after multiple failed login attempts. Proceeding with password reset and account unlock."

Work note 2 (19:57:28):

"Reset user password in Active Directory and unlocked account. Instructed user to log in with temporary password and change immediately after next login. User confirmed successful login. Monitoring for recurrence."

The activity log also captures all field changes automatically, providing a full audit trail of the ticket's history with timestamps.

The screenshot displays the 'Notes' tab of a ticketing system interface. At the top, there are tabs for 'Notes', 'Related Records', and 'Resolution Information'. Below these, there are sections for 'Watch list', 'Work notes list', and a 'Work notes' input field with a 'Post' button. A checkbox for 'Comments (Customer visible)' is also present. The main section, 'Activities: 4', lists four activities performed by a 'System Administrator'. Each activity entry includes a timestamp and a description of the action taken. The activities are: 1. 'Assigned to Incident state' (2026-05-12 20:05:30), 2. 'Reset user password in Active Directory and unlocked account' (2026-05-12 19:57:28), 3. 'Contacted user via phone' (2026-05-12 19:56:35), and 4. 'Impact: 2 - Medium, Incident state: New, Opened by: System Administrator, Priority: 3 - Moderate' (2026-05-12 19:51:14).

Activity	Timestamp
Assigned to Incident state	2026-05-12 20:05:30
Reset user password in Active Directory and unlocked account	2026-05-12 19:57:28
Contacted user via phone	2026-05-12 19:56:35
Impact: 2 - Medium, Incident state: New, Opened by: System Administrator, Priority: 3 - Moderate	2026-05-12 19:51:14

Figure 3 — Notes tab showing two work notes and field change activity log with timestamps

Section 5: Resolving the Ticket

Resolution Information

Once the issue was confirmed resolved by the user, the ticket was closed out using the Resolution Information tab. This is a critical step — incomplete resolution documentation is one of the most common mistakes new helpdesk technicians make.

The following resolution details were recorded:

Resolution code	Solution provided
Resolved by	System Administrator
Resolved date/time	2026-05-12 20:05:19
Resolution notes	User account was locked out in Active Directory after multiple failed login attempts. Performed password reset and unlocked the account via ADUC. User was instructed to set a new password at next logon per company policy. User confirmed successful login. Issue resolved.

The resolution code "Solution provided" indicates the root cause was identified and permanently fixed — as opposed to codes like "Workaround provided" (temporary fix) or "User error" (no technical action needed).

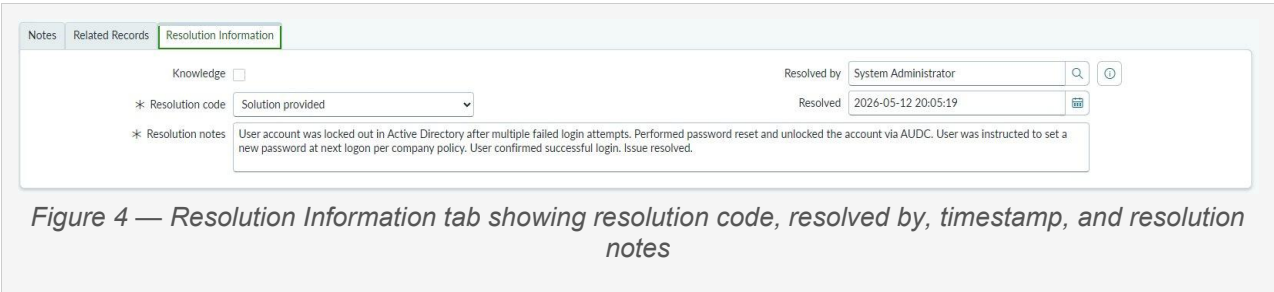


Figure 4 — Resolution Information tab showing resolution code, resolved by, timestamp, and resolution notes

Section 6: Closed Ticket in the Queue

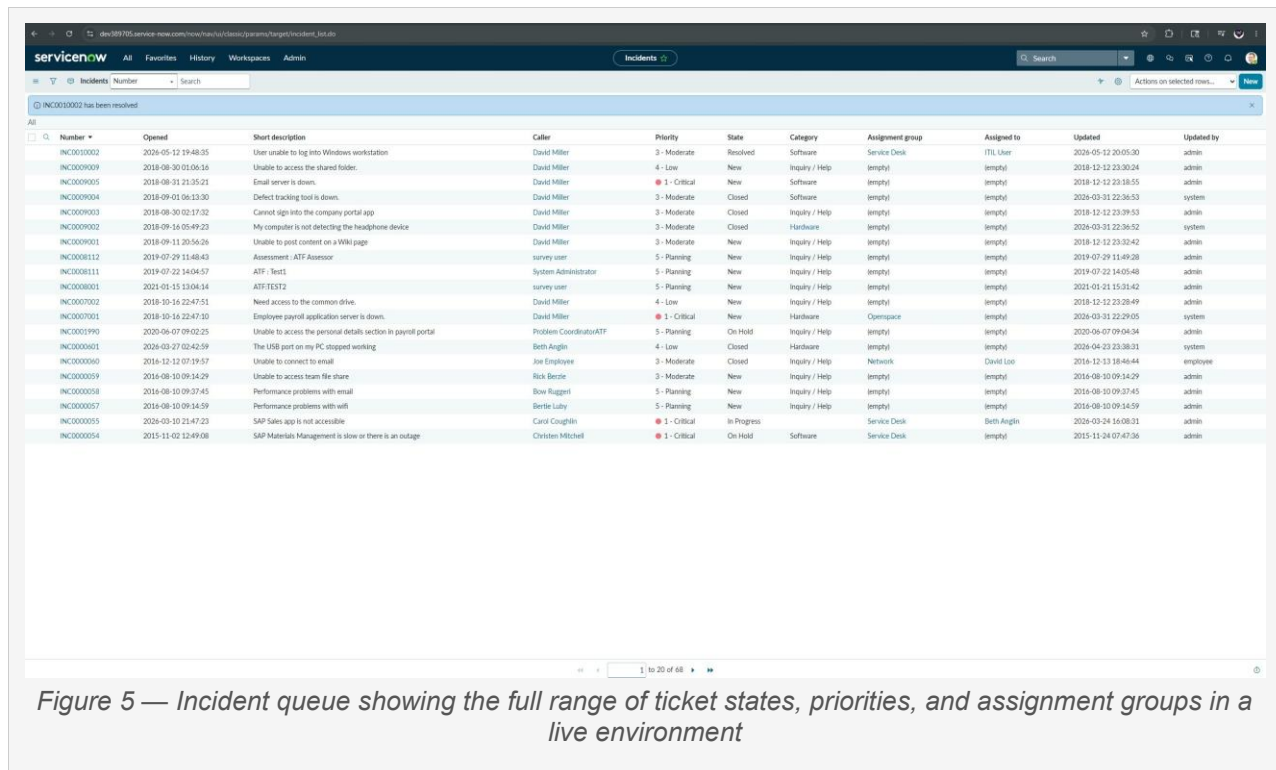
Ticket Lifecycle Complete

After resolution, the incident list reflects the completed ticket. The queue shows the full range of ticket states present in a real helpdesk environment — New, In Progress, On Hold, Closed — giving a realistic view of what a technician monitors daily.

Key observations from the incident queue:

- P1 Critical tickets (red dot) such as "Email server is down" and "Employee payroll application server is down" represent major incidents requiring immediate escalation

- P3-P4 tickets represent the bulk of daily Tier 1 work — password issues, connectivity problems, application access
- On Hold tickets indicate waiting on the user, a third party, or a change window
- The SLA timers on each ticket drive urgency — missing an SLA response target is a key performance metric for helpdesk teams



Summary

This lab successfully demonstrated the full incident ticket lifecycle in ServiceNow, covering all core Tier 1 helpdesk workflows:

1. Provisioned a free ServiceNow Personal Developer Instance (PDI) running the Australia release
2. Navigated the Incident List and understood ticket queue management, priority color coding, and SLA indicators
3. Created incident INC0010002 for a simulated account lockout scenario with proper categorization, impact, urgency, and assignment
4. Updated ticket state from New to In Progress and assigned to the ITIL User agent role

5. Documented two work notes capturing real-time troubleshooting steps and resolution actions
6. Resolved the ticket with resolution code "Solution provided" and detailed resolution notes
7. Observed the closed ticket in the live queue alongside other real-world ticket scenarios

ServiceNow incident management is a foundational skill for any Tier 1 helpdesk role. The ability to create, document, and resolve tickets accurately — especially with thorough work notes and resolution documentation — is one of the most valued competencies in entry-level IT support positions.